ASSEMBlY SÜGGESTED

A play by
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SCENE ONE: BOLT A

The stage is absolutely overrun with cardboard boxes. Boxes stacked on boxes. Boxes nested inside other boxes. One box has clearly collapsed under the weight of other boxes. Centre stage: a box labeled "CHAIR." Surrounding it:

"CHAIR (PART 1)"
"CHAIR (OPTIONAL)"
"CHAIR (BACKUP)"
"CHAIR (WHY?)"
"CHAIR (DO NOT OPEN FIRST)"

JOULE kneels amid the cardboard chaos, calm, determined, already sweating slightly.

JOULE finds the instruction booklet. It is absurdly thick.

JOULE
Oh.

She flips pages. The NARRATOR enters the stage and stands front and center.

NARRATOR
Twenty-six steps.
Four languages.
Three warnings about structural integrity.
And one overly poetic paragraph about Scandinavian design philosophy.

JOULE clears her throat. Reads.

JOULE (reading instructions)
Step one: Locate bolt A.

NARRATOR
Joule, our quite frankly sensational protagonist, has never been partial to instructions. However, last week was New Year's, and Joule had decided that she wanted to do things right this time. Perhaps she will even be rewarded by

the end of this performance, with something resembling furniture.

The NARRATOR walks to the side of the stage, to a stool near the front. There is distance between her and the scene.

Joule locates the bolt after looking in several boxes.

JOULE (reading instructions)
Step two: Locate the Allen key.

She digs through a pile of cardboard. Finds it. Holds it up.

JOULE
Okay.

NARRATOR
The Allen key is truly a study in arrogance. Minuscule, yet certain it can hold up a full-grown human. Though Joule didn't envy that confidence, she had enough of her own.

JOULE scans ahead.

JOULE (reading instructions)
Step three: Ask Veronika to hand you the Allen key.

She freezes and looks down at the Allen key already in her hand.

JOULE
Step four: Fasten bolt A to the Allen key.

She tries to proceed anyway. Fits the bolt. It doesn't align.

She tries again. Still nothing.

NARRATOR
Joule attempted to bypass the instruction, only to discover that the instruction had anticipated this exact hubris.

JOULE struggles, then eventually starts looking in the other boxes. She opens the largest one and VERONIKA is there. JOULE is taken aback.

VERONIKA
Hi, I'm Veronika.

JOULE flinches.

JOULE
Jesus Christ.

They both stand in silence for a moment. JOULE looks back at the booklet.

JOULE (reading instructions)
Uh… Step three: Please ask Veronika to hand you the Allen key.

She looks at Veronika. Awkward.

JOULE
Can you—
Sorry—
Can you hand me the Allen key?

VERONIKA looks at the Allen key already in Joule's hand. Joule gestures helplessly to the booklet.

VERONIKA
Okay.

VERONIKA gently takes the Allen key from Joule. Hands it back.

JOULE
Thank you.

JOULE reads on.

JOULE (reading instructions)
Step four: Fasten bolt A to the Allen key.

VERONIKA crouches beside Joule. Efficient. Focused. The bolt clicks into place. Joule inhales excitedly, and looks at Veronika.

Lights isolate NARRATOR.

NARRATOR
And just like that. Progress. Ladies and gentlemen, tonight we witness the chronicle of a young woman who had resolved, at long last, to do everything right.

VERONIKA looks at the remaining boxes.

Full blackout.

SCENE TWO: MEET VERONIKA

NARRATOR
Oh—wait, lights on for a second.

Lights isolate NARRATOR.

NARRATOR
What an irresponsible oversight—to commence our tale without presenting its most bewitching figure. Veronika. Would you be so kind as to join me?

VERONIKA does. The stage lights accommodate VERONIKA.

NARRATOR (speaking like a beauty pageant host)
Veronika stands at 5 foot 6 inches, though I'm almost sure she's 5 foot 8.
Veronika has 3 tattoos, a cat named Mango and half a degree from art school.

NARRATOR (to Veronika)
Do a little spin for us.

VERONIKA spins.

NARRATOR
Stunning. But Veronika's most notable trait is how good a friend she is to Joule, which I'll get her back to.

Veronika returns to the main stage, lights up. The Narrator steps back to the side.

SCENE THREE: THESE DAYS

Evening. The chair parts are still untouched.
JOULE sits cross-legged on the floor, phone in hand.

JOULE
Okay. Listen to this.

VERONIKA
I'm bracing.

JOULE
Jay just texted "There's nothing good on TV these days."

A beat.

VERONIKA
What does that even mean?

JOULE
Exactly.

VERONIKA
"These days" compared to when?

JOULE
Right? Which days are we talking about?

VERONIKA
Name the days. Oh wait, you can't. You weren't there.

JOULE
You watched whatever your parents put on and thought it was the height of culture.

VERONIKA
Also, statistically impossible.

JOULE
What is?

VERONIKA
That there is “nothing good.”

JOULE
Exactly. That’s not an opinion, that’s a failure of search.

VERONIKA
I want sources.

JOULE
Peer-reviewed.

VERONIKA
Define “good.”

JOULE
Define “nothing.”

VERONIKA
Define “TV.”

JOULE
Like, say you failed to find something you like.

VERONIKA
Say your attention span collapsed.

JOULE
Say the algorithm stopped spoon-feeding you.

VERONIKA
Say you miss being told what’s good.

JOULE
Oof.

A beat.

VERONIKA
The only acceptable “these days” argument is economic.

JOULE (with a voice like “finally, someone said it”)
Yes.

VERONIKA
Because we have data.

JOULE
We have inflation and wage stagnation.

VERONIKA
We have smaller apartments and worse couches, which directly affects the viewing experience.

JOULE
No one’s talking about that.

VERONIKA
Yeah, why is no one talking about this.

They both work in silence for a beat. It’s clear they want to keep talking.

JOULE
Also, people forget how much bad TV there was.

VERONIKA
So much bad TV.

JOULE
We just don’t remember it. No one’s like, “Wow, they don’t make failed pilots like they used to.”

JOULE types on her phone.

VERONIKA
What are you responding?

JOULE
I don’t know.

VERONIKA
Just be like me and never reply.

Joule smiles and rolls her eyes.

Lights isolate the NARRATOR.

NARRATOR
The girls had quickly become inseparable—an extra key was cut, messages began with "are you both free," and the laundry ran twice as often.

SCENE FOUR: THE SWEATER

Same room. Later.

The chair is halfway built. The apartment is still conspicuously unfinished.

JOULE and VERONIKA sit on the floor, tools spread between them. They work easily now, without thinking too much about it.

JOULE
Okay, what's a food that… you'd want as your first meal if you ever went to space?

VERONIKA
Sushi.

JOULE
But you're a vegetarian.

VERONIKA
Yeah, vegetarian sushi.

JOULE
And if you had to pick only one food to eat for the rest of your life?

VERONIKA
Non-vegetarian sushi.

Joule laughs.

VERONIKA
Okay, favorite type of… lawsuit.

JOULE
Class-action. Too easy.

VERONIKA
I'm a property dispute fan.

JOULE
Imagine having property to dispute.

VERONIKA
One day…

Veronika and Joule take a mental note of their surroundings.

JOULE
You know I've had this place for two years?

VERONIKA
Oh yeah?

JOULE
Yeah. I kept telling myself I'd furnish it once I felt settled.

VERONIKA looks around, taking inventory.

VERONIKA
No doors. Terrible draft. One massive stage light for some reason.

JOULE
Yeah, it's freezing and I feel like I have no privacy, but the rent is super cheap for Toronto.

JOULE (whispering)
It starts with a 1—for this *whole* apartment.

VERONIKA gets a text, looks at her phone, and stops paying attention to Joule.

VERONIKA
Oh, I forgot my friends are hosting a salon tonight.

JOULE nods.

VERONIKA (while texting)
Tonight's theme is "chosen family"… Okay, I'm gonna go in like 5.

JOULE
Stay for one more step?

VERONIKA
Uh… sure…

VERONIKA grabs her purse, and her vape, which she immediately uses. JOULE forces a grin.

JOULE
Okay. Step eight… thank Veronika?

JOULE
Uh, thanks?

VERONIKA
For what?

JOULE checks the instructions

JOULE
It doesn't say. I don't know, I guess for helping me, and being supportive, unlike plank B—

JOULE holds up plank B.

VERONIKA (possibly joking, possibly not)
Okay, cringe…

JOULE (taken aback)
Yeah, just thanks 'cause this has been meaningful and—

VERONIKA
Ahh, stop—you know I get awkward with compliments.

JOULE
Sorry…

VERONIKA
Actually, I'll let you thank me for this.

VERONIKA stands, crosses the room, opens a box marked "MISC." She pulls out a soft yellow sweater, folded neatly. Hands it to JOULE.

VERONIKA
I got you something.

JOULE looks up, surprised.

JOULE
You did?

VERONIKA
'Cause it's freezing in here.

JOULE takes it, a little caught.

JOULE
Thank you.

NARRATOR
Joule appreciated, for the first time in her life, the feeling of being seen.
She was familiar with recognition—she got plenty of that. She was outgoing, fun, loud. It wasn't a mystery why people noticed her.
But this was different.
This was someone being curious about her. Not because she demanded the room's attention, but because the room quietly decided to give it.

JOULE slips it on. Immediate relief. She exhales, then catches herself.

They sit again. Closer now. They resume building.

JOULE
Honestly, this is the most progress I've made on anything in here.

VERONIKA
You should pick another project.

JOULE considers this.

JOULE
Like what?

VERONIKA looks around.

VERONIKA
A table.

JOULE
Ambitious.

VERONIKA
I'm already pretty good at Chair, god knows I'll be amazing at Table.

They share a look that lasts just long enough to register. JOULE reaches for the instruction booklet out of habit. Skims a page. Her smile flickers—almost imperceptibly. VERONIKA gets up, grabs her jacket and blows a kiss at JOULE.

Lights isolate on the Narrator.

NARRATOR
It occurred to Joule, this might not be a one-time thing.
Though just to be sure, she took extra-long breaks before opening the instruction manual, now her favorite book… the kind you stretch out, just in case.

Momentary blackout, then lights up.

SCENE FIVE: NO, WAIT

JOULE and VERONIKA drink wine while sitting cross-legged on the floor. VERONIKA looks at the chair.

VERONIKA
You know I didn't really want to say it before, but honestly this chair is really ugly.

JOULE
No, don't worry—I was thinking that too.

VERONIKA
Okay, hopefully the next step is fast—I wanna head out soon.

JOULE (reading instructions)
Step ten: apologize to the chair for judging it.

A beat.

JOULE and VERONIKA apologize in unison, acting as though they were children being forced to apologize to someone.

JOULE
Where are you headed tonight?

VERONIKA
Oh I'm meeting up with my friends for a pre before Amir’s band’s show.

An awkward silence.

JOULE (slightly hurt)
Oh… sounds fun.

VERONIKA
You can come to the show.

JOULE
Really?

VERONIKA
I mean, it’s a public event, so…

JOULE
Oh… yeah, maybe.

VERONIKA
Sorry… I just don’t really like mixing friend groups… makes me anxious.

JOULE is hurt, but tries to hide it.

Lights isolate NARRATOR.

NARRATOR
Wait—no… it didn’t really go like that… hang on.

A pause.

NARRATOR
Okay, yes. I got it.

Lights up.

JOULE (reading instructions)
Step ten: apologize to the chair for judging it.

A beat.

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JOULE
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Oh… sounds fun.

VERONIKA
You can come to the show.
JOULE
Really?

VERONIKA
I don’t want you to feel left out—come, it’s a public event.

JOULE
Oh… yeah, maybe.

VERONIKA
About the pre, I’m weird about this stuff… I just don’t really like mixing friend groups… makes me anxious. I know how you feel about being left out—

JOULE (too quickly)
It’s okay.

A beat.

VERONIKA
No, wait.
I’m not saying “no.” I’m saying I’m scared.

She forces herself to look at Joule.

VERONIKA (cont’d)
Come to the pre.
Like—twenty minutes. I’ll stay with you the whole time. If it’s weird, we leave.

JOULE
Are you sure?

VERONIKA
No.

Then, like she’s ripping off a bandage:

VERONIKA (cont’d)
But I’m asking anyway.

She takes out her phone and starts typing. Fast. No time to overthink.

VERONIKA (cont’d)
I’m texting them right now.

JOULE
You don’t have to do that.

VERONIKA
I know.

She hits send.

VERONIKA (cont’d)
Okay. Done.
Now I have to survive it.

JOULE laughs, small, caught-off-guard.

JOULE
Okay. Yeah. Okay.

Lights isolate NARRATOR.

NARRATOR
Joule didn’t go. She stayed home and read.
She kept thinking about how she’d describe the book to Veronika later.
Joule spent a lot of time with Veronika.
Most of it. Without her.

SCENE SIX: SOULMATE

The chair is sturdier now. Not finished. Close.
JOULE is tightening something. VERONIKA holds the frame steady. It’s intimate work. They don’t look at each other while it happens. VERONIKA is now on a literal pedestal.

JOULE
You know, I feel like my soulmate has to be a woman.

VERONIKA pauses, then continues holding the frame.

VERONIKA
What about Jay?

JOULE
He’s great, it’s been a nice few years, but I don’t know if a man could understand every part of me like a woman could.

VERONIKA
There are definitely women-only experiences… but I guess I don’t think I feel the need to be understood as deeply as you do.

JOULE
I wish I was built like that… but I just feel like being with a man is trading attraction for understanding.

VERONIKA
Sounds lonely

JOULE
Yeah…

A beat.

JOULE (trying to be casual)
Step… twelve.

She opens the booklet. Reads.

JOULE (reading instructions)
"While fastening the left support, share one fear you don't usually share."

JOULE lets out a small laugh like it's ridiculous.

JOULE
Okay. Um. I think I'm… hard to keep.

VERONIKA blinks. Not judgment. Not reassurance either. Just… receiving.

VERONIKA
Why?

JOULE
Because I'm— I'm intense. And I know that's annoying.

VERONIKA
It's kind of main character to be intense.

JOULE stops moving.

NARRATOR
There it was again. Joule was seen. If Joule ever dared to say something small and unflattering about herself, Veronika never rushed to contradict it. Instead, she offered a quiet observation—one that forced Joule to recontextualize the remark.

How lucky was Joule to share a space with someone so insightful, someone so insightful about *her*.

JOULE swallows. Keeps working.

JOULE (reading instructions)
Step thirteen: Remove the nails from Plank C.

Joule starts removing nails.

VERONIKA
Why do you think the plank came nailed, if we're just going to take them out?

JOULE
Eh, I prefer my planks pre-nailed.

JOULE completes the removal of three nails.

JOULE (reading instructions)
Step fourteen: Rotate Plank D until it "feels correct."

VERONIKA grabs the plank and starts rotating. The girls both watch the plank carefully until it's clear to both of them at the same time that it "felt correct."

VERONIKA
There it is.

JOULE
Yeah, yeah—that's exactly right.

JOULE looks at the instructions again.

JOULE
Step fifteen: Check local regulations… Uh…

Joule starts flipping to other pages.

Lights isolate on the Narrator.

NARRATOR
Let's quickly clarify something. Joule was not naïve.
She saw everything—the neglect, the vanishing acts, the unhealthy coping mechanisms.
Veronika offered less. Joule just didn't care.

Chemistry never concerned itself with good judgement anyway.

SCENE SEVEN: PODCAST CHAIR

Same room. Later still.

The chair looks nearly complete. A few parts remain. It's close enough that someone could sit—if they trusted it.

JOULE and VERONIKA take a break. They sit on the floor. The sweater is on Joule. It looks lived-in now.

JOULE watches VERONIKA in a way that is almost embarrassing to witness. Like she's trying to memorize her.

JOULE
You know what would actually be awesome?

VERONIKA
What?

JOULE
If we were building a gaming chair.

A beat.

VERONIKA
No.

JOULE
Hear me out.

VERONIKA
I will not.

JOULE
Like, a truly insane one.

VERONIKA
With the holes.

JOULE
With the holes.

VERONIKA
For airflow.

JOULE
For performance and dominance.

VERONIKA
It would have LED lights.

JOULE
Of course, it would glow when you're losing.

VERONIKA
It would smell faintly of energy drink.

JOULE
It would have opinions about women.

They laugh.

VERONIKA
Okay, no.

A beat.

VERONIKA
It should be more like a podcast chair.

JOULE
A chair that says (lower voice) "I'm here to have conversations."

VERONIKA
"I don't lean back, I lean in."

Veronika clears her throat. They mime sitting very upright.

VERONIKA
Welcome back to The Hard Conversation. Today our guests are Chad Muscleson, self-proclaimed alpha male, author of "Why Women Aren't Funny," and a random lady that was hanging out outside the studio today.

JOULE
Today we're unpacking—

VERONIKA
—why women are a distraction.

JOULE
Brought to you by—
Squarespace.

VERONIKA
No.

JOULE
Casper.

VERONIKA
Nah.

JOULE
Athletic Greens?

VERONIKA
There it is.

JOULE
This chair doesn't own a television.

VERONIKA
This chair doesn't believe in television.

JOULE
This chair watches ideas.

VERONIKA
This chair says (British) "One mustn't lounge."

JOULE (joining, worse British)
"One perches."

VERONIKA
"Perching keeps the spine honest."

JOULE (back to her regular accent)
Wait, I actually don’t own a TV.

VERONIKA
Oh yeah…

JOULE
Just don’t have the space.

VERONIKA
It’s purely a spatial decision.

JOULE
Purely.

VERONIKA grabs her vape and starts using it.

JOULE (British)
“This chair believes that men aren’t men these days.”

VERONIKA (acting embarrassed by Joule)
Okay, I feel like we’re getting super distracted—let’s just get back to building.

JOULE
Oh, yeah—of course.

JOULE reaches for the instruction manual.

JOULE
Okay, next step: tighten bolt C onto plank F.

JOULE proceeds to work on that.

JOULE (reading instructions)
Oh, there’s an optional instruction here… Step A: Participants are encouraged to leave their comfort zone.

VERONIKA
I would literally never.

JOULE
Then I won’t either.

VERONIKA
I'm not falling for this kind of self-helpy… propaganda.

JOULE (reading)
"Leaving one's comfort zone has been shown to help people succeed in all aspects of their lives."

VERONIKA
Okay. I didn't realize the instruction manual was a primary source.

JOULE
"To review primary research, see Appendix C."

VERONIKA
Of course.

JOULE flips to Appendix C.

JOULE
"Jenkins et al., 2007."

VERONIKA
Well, what was the methodology of the study?

JOULE (reading)
"Critiques of methodological rigor are common among individuals exhibiting high cognitive defensiveness."

VERONIKA
Wow.

JOULE
"Such defensiveness is often mistaken for discernment."

VERONIKA
Well this feels personal.

JOULE
"The reader should note that this is actually not at all personal."

VERONIKA
I—

JOULE closes the book.

JOULE
It’s an optional step—let’s just skip it.

VERONIKA becomes quiet and is clearly uncomfortable. She stares at the ground. JOULE tries to change the subject.

JOULE
What was your business idea again?

VERONIKA slowly perks back up as she explains.

VERONIKA
Oh yeah, it’s a subscription service that sends you one carefully written email a month—something that reframes whatever you’re dealing with so it feels less urgent.

JOULE (trying to be encouraging)
Love it… But how can you reframe their situation if it’s not actually about their situation?

VERONIKA
Because people don’t experience events directly.
They experience narratives about events.

JOULE
Okay but—

VERONIKA
If you shift the narrative, the event becomes secondary. It’s basic phenomenology.

A beat. JOULE’s face screams “this makes no sense.”

JOULE
…damn. That’s really smart.

VERONIKA
Right?!

JOULE
You did it again.

Lights off. Joule and Veronika leave the stage. Then lights on.

SCENE EIGHT: WHEN JOULE FELL IN LOVE

The NARRATOR enters alone. She tidies lightly as she speaks.

NARRATOR
When Joule fell in love, nothing really changed.

A beat.

NARRATOR
But for the first time, at twenty-seven—

She smiles at the audience.

NARRATOR (cont'd)
she got to feel seventeen.

NARRATOR (cont'd)
Joule had a real job. Consulting. B2B SaaS fintech. Engineers. Tech people. Very confident opinions from Reddit. And then—Veronika. Art school. Which meant she cared about things. Real things. Politics. Philosophy. Why any of this is the way it is.

She resumes cleaning.

NARRATOR (cont'd)
She was the smartest person Joule had ever met. So Joule listened. Veronika didn't like being overwhelmed. So Joule learned something: not everything has to be said in the moment. Some things wait. For the right time.

A small smile.

NARRATOR
Joule got very good at timing.

Lights off

SCENE NINE: A CHEAP CHAIR

Lights on. Same room. Later. Joule and Veronika are in their usual spots.

The chair is almost finished. There's a lingering tension in the air now.

VERONIKA is on her phone. JOULE is reading the booklet, but trying to look casual about it.

JOULE
We're on step nineteen.

VERONIKA
Mm.

JOULE
Okay. Step nineteen: Confirm Veronika is present.

A beat. JOULE looks up.

VERONIKA is physically there. But she doesn't look up and doesn't move.

JOULE
You there V?

VERONIKA (still staring at her phone)
Yeah what's up

JOULE
Nothing.

JOULE reads again.

JOULE (reading instructions)
"Proceed only if both parties are engaged."

JOULE stares at the page. A small panic. Then: she flips it like maybe it'll change.

JOULE
I feel like we've been trying to finish this step for a bit now

VERONIKA
Joule—

JOULE
It's fine.

VERONIKA
Literally just chill for two seconds

JOULE
Sorry...

A beat.

VERONIKA (soft, careful)
Sometimes it feels like you're building… more than what's here.

JOULE's smile falters.

JOULE
Okay. Then tell me what's here.

VERONIKA looks at her. There's affection. And something else. Distance pretending to be kindness.

VERONIKA
A cheap chair

The moment lingers

JOULE
I just want to do it right.

VERONIKA's face shifts. Not anger. Something closer to exhaustion.

VERONIKA
Yeah.

A long pause.

JOULE (reading instructions)
Okay, Step twenty: Before attaching the final support, say what you want.

JOULE looks up. VERONIKA looks back, guarded.

JOULE
I want—

She stops. Swallows.

JOULE (cont'd)
I want to keep doing this.

VERONIKA nods. Too fast.

VERONIKA
Yeah. Sure.

JOULE stares.

JOULE (reading instructions)
"Attach final support. Tighten until stable."

JOULE begins tightening. The chair wobbles less. Then more. It's delicate. A balancing act.

VERONIKA (finally becomes engaged)
You're over-tightening.

JOULE
I'm following it.

VERONIKA
Sometimes the instructions are wrong.

JOULE pauses. Looks at VERONIKA like she's said something obscene.

JOULE
They're not wrong.

VERONIKA
They're… printed.

JOULE
Okay but if we do it right, it'll hold.

JOULE tightens again, carefully. The chair steadies—just enough to tempt fate.

VERONIKA
Okay.

They lift it together. The chair stands. A beat.

It's not perfect. But it stands.

NARRATOR
Milestones are tricky. This didn't really feel like one.

JOULE smiles, relieved. VERONIKA smiles, dutiful.

Blackout.

SCENE TEN: THE MISSING PIECE

The chair stands upright now, but unfinished. One final crossbar is missing.

JOULE is on her hands and knees, checking inside the empty box. Calm. Focused.

VERONIKA stands nearby, arms folded. Watching.

VERONIKA
It was here before.

JOULE
Okay. Then it's probably just… somewhere.

She keeps looking.

VERONIKA
You always say that.

A beat.

JOULE
I just mean… we'll find it.

VERONIKA
Right.

Silence.

VERONIKA (cont'd)
You didn't move it?

JOULE
I don't think so.

VERONIKA
Hmm.

A small sound. Not quite a sigh.

NARRATOR
Veronika was not angry. Which was worse. Anger would have been something Joule could respond to.

JOULE pulls out a scrap of cardboard. Checks it. Nothing.

VERONIKA
It's just interesting.

JOULE
What is?

VERONIKA
That every time something goes missing,
it's never your fault—

NARRATOR
Joule considered speaking. Not defensively, just accurately. She imagined the sentence. Measured its weight. Then pictured what would follow.
Silence.
Withdrawal.
The quiet punishment of being left alone with correctness.

JOULE keeps searching. VERONIKA grabs a plank and a peg and starts working on the chair.

VERONIKA
You do take a long time with things.

JOULE
I like to be thorough.

VERONIKA
I guess.

A pause.

VERONIKA (cont'd)
It's probably why your apartment's still empty. You know.

JOULE freezes. Just for half a second.

NARRATOR
This was the moment. The one Joule would later revisit with surgical precision. She could say something. She could ask not to be spoken to that way. She could introduce friction. Instead—

JOULE (trying to diffuse)
Well I've got a chair now.

VERONIKA (walking back her aggression)
I didn't mean it like that.

JOULE
I know.

NARRATOR
Joule actually wasn't quite sure if she meant it like that.

A beat. The tension hums.

Then—quietly—the NARRATOR steps forward. She pulls the missing piece out of her jacket and slides it across the floor. It stops between JOULE and VERONIKA.

Silence.

VERONIKA
Oh.

VERONIKA (softening immediately)
I'm sorry.

She kneels. Picks it up.

VERONIKA (cont'd)
That was— I shouldn't have—

JOULE
It's okay.

VERONIKA
I've just been anxious.

JOULE
I know.

They share a look. Relief. Familiarity restored. Veronika fits the crossbar into place. The chair stabilizes.

VERONIKA
There. See? All good.

JOULE
Yeah.

A smile. Genuine.

Lights isolate on the Narrator.

NARRATOR
Joule did not register this as cruelty. She registered it as Veronika. A language she had learned to translate without ever asking why she was the only one fluent.

Lights up.

SCENE ELEVEN: THE CONFESSION

The chair is almost finished now. Solid enough to trust. Almost.

JOULE sits on the floor, back against it. VERONIKA sits beside her, knees pulled to her chest.

A long silence. Not uncomfortable.

VERONIKA
I'm bad at people.

JOULE doesn't rush to reassure. She waits.

VERONIKA (cont'd)
I always have been.
I don't reach out.
I don't check in.
I just—
I stay where I am.

A breath.

VERONIKA (cont'd)
Sometimes I think one day I'll look up and realize I'm completely alone.

JOULE turns slightly toward her.

JOULE
That sounds scary.

VERONIKA
It is.
But it's also easier.

A beat.

VERONIKA (cont'd)
I'd rather be a little sad at home than risk being rejected.

NARRATOR
This was not an apology. It was an explanation.

And explanations, when delivered gently, can feel indistinguishable from change.

A pause. The NARRATOR gets emotional.

NARRATOR
I hate explanations. They don’t DO anything… It’s just saying stuff.
Explanations are what you give when you don’t intend to give more.

VERONIKA
I guess I’m just… lazy about love.

JOULE smiles softly.

JOULE
You’re not lazy. You’re just careful.

VERONIKA looks at her.

VERONIKA
I don’t want to hurt you.

JOULE
I know.

A beat.

JOULE (cont’d)
And for what it’s worth, I’m not going anywhere.

VERONIKA doesn’t respond immediately.

VERONIKA
Thank you.

She rests her head lightly against Joule’s shoulder.

NARRATOR
Joule heard fear and mistook it for effort. She heard self-awareness and mistook it for progress. And because Veronika could name the pattern, Joule forgave its repetition.

JOULE closes her eyes. Peaceful.

JOULE
We all have stuff. *She laughs quietly.* I'm sure I'm oblivious to half of mine.

VERONIKA
You're not that bad.

JOULE
See? Already generous.

They smile. Joule picks up the booklet.

JOULE (reading the booklet)
Step twenty-five: we're almost done. Attach board B to the frame.

JOULE follows the instructions, then stands back to gaze at the chair.

SCENE TWELVE: THE BREAK

The chair is complete now. It stands center stage. Upright. Finished.

JOULE adjusts it. Tests it gently. It wobbles—just slightly.

JOULE
It's not level.

VERONIKA
It's fine.

JOULE
It wobbles.

VERONIKA
Only if you apply uneven pressure.

A beat.

JOULE
We could tighten it.

VERONIKA
We already did.

Silence.

JOULE crouches. Reaches for the Allen key.

VERONIKA
You don’t need to fix everything.

JOULE
I’m not fixing, I’m just—

VERONIKA
You always do this.

A beat.

JOULE
Do what?

VERONIKA
Make things bigger than they are.

JOULE
Okay, I’m just going to pretend I didn’t hear that and go back to the manual.

VERONIKA
You’re so sensitive sometimes.

JOULE
Okay. Step twenty-six: each of you compliment the other.

They both groan immediately.

VERONIKA
Oh, absolutely not.

JOULE
This is humiliating.

VERONIKA
What even constitutes a compliment?

JOULE
Something you'd immediately argue with.

VERONIKA
Well, I can't argue with that.

JOULE
When Bonnie called you pretty, you literally said it was just the lighting.

VERONIKA
Okay but the lighting was so good that day.

Joule laughs.

JOULE
The fluorescent lighting… of the pho shop?

VERONIKA
I'd literally take my wedding pictures there just for the lighting.

JOULE
Just do the wedding there, they have food.

VERONIKA
You know what we should do? Go wedding dress shopping, just for fun.

Joule doesn't respond immediately. An awkward moment passes.

JOULE
You're… really hard to predict.

VERONIKA
Backhanded, but I deserved that.

JOULE
I just don't think I make things bigger than they are.

VERONIKA
You do.

JOULE (defeated)
Is that bad?

VERONIKA doesn’t answer immediately.

VERONIKA
It’s just… a lot.

Veronika grabs her vape and uses it.

NARRATOR
Joule felt it then. The familiar tightening.
All of a sudden, things felt so fragile… Listen, I don’t know about you guys, but I don’t even know what Joule did? She was nothing but nice, and V acts like that’s a bad thing.

JOULE (attempting to capture some confidence)
Okay. Then what do you want?

VERONIKA
I don’t want anything.

JOULE
Doesn’t seem like it.

VERONIKA
I just want things to be… lighter.

JOULE nods. Swallows. Takes a deep breath.

JOULE
I can do that.

NARRATOR
What Joule is trying to say is that she can make herself smaller, if that’s even possible at this point.

VERONIKA sits on the chair. It creaks.

JOULE
Wait—

VERONIKA
It’s fine.

She shifts her weight. The wobble increases.

JOULE
Please don’t—

VERONIKA
See? Still standing.

JOULE steps back. Hurt flickers—quickly contained.

JOULE
I just wish, sometimes, that you’d meet me where I am.

VERONIKA, still on the chair, looks away.

VERONIKA
I don’t know how to do that without losing myself.

A pause.

NARRATOR
At first,
Joule wanted to understand this generously.
After all, she had warned us.
She had named the pattern.
She had never promised more than presence.

The NARRATOR steps slightly closer. Voice tightening.

NARRATOR (cont’d)
And still, watching it happen, I find myself becoming… impatient.

The NARRATOR’s emotions get the best of them.

NARRATOR (cont’d)
Sorry, just… give me a second. It’s just hard to watch.

The NARRATOR wipes tears on her sleeve. JOULE breathes.

JOULE
I’m not asking you to lose yourself.

VERONIKA
It feels like I would.

JOULE
I don’t even know what we’re fighting about right now.

VERONIKA becomes still, her expression hardens. She withdraws, and still doesn’t look at Joule.

VERONIKA
I can’t do this right now.

NARRATOR
There it is. Classic Veronika.

The NARRATOR laughs—sharp, unexpected.

NARRATOR (cont’d)
Oh, fuck it.

Everything stops.

NARRATOR
We all know this isn’t about a chair.

She exhales. Unravels. Starts to unbutton her jacket.

NARRATOR (cont’d)
I’ve been trying—
so hard—
to tell this nicely.

She pulls off her jacket. Underneath: the same tattered yellow sweater Joule wears.

A quiet intake of breath.

NARRATOR (cont’d)
But I think… I think she’s about to break my heart.

Blackout.

SCENE THIRTEEN: JOULE 2.0

Lights up

The NARRATOR now stands where JOULE stood.

She is Joule.

VERONIKA remains by the chair. Guarded. No longer on the pedestal.

JOULE 2.0
Don’t shut down.

VERONIKA
I’m not—

JOULE 2.0
You are.

A beat.

VERONIKA
I just need space.

JOULE 2.0 (angry)
You always need space—
when I need clarity.

JOULE 2.0 (more sad than angry)
Do you know how lonely that feels?

VERONIKA stiffens.

VERONIKA
I didn’t ask you to stay.

JOULE 2.0
No. You just let me.

Silence.

VERONIKA
That’s not fair.

JOULE 2.0
I know.

A beat. Softer.

JOULE 2.0 (cont'd)
But it's true.

VERONIKA looks at her. Finally.

VERONIKA
I don't want to be the person you build your life around.

JOULE 2.0
Well, I feel kind of dumb, because I already did.

VERONIKA doesn't respond to this. She looks at the chair, then:

VERONIKA
We missed a support.

JOULE 2.0 takes a deep breath.

JOULE 2.0
Why didn't you tell me you were seeing someone?

VERONIKA sits. Still. Listening.

VERONIKA
I told you. Can you pass me bolt C.

Joule passes the bolt.

JOULE 2.0
No, you didn't.

VERONIKA
I did. I texted. Do you have the Allen key?

JOULE pauses.

JOULE 2.0
No—I—I remember—

VERONIKA
I need one of those small metal spirals.

JOULE 2.0
…a screw?

VERONIKA
They named the spiral after getting s—

She stops. Her face changes.

JOULE 2.0 (cont'd)
Wait. Yeah, you did text me.

A beat.

JOULE 2.0 (quiet)
I'm sorry.

She laughs once. Small. Mortified.

JOULE 2.0 (cont'd)
That's… that's embarrassing.

VERONIKA watches her. Gentle.

VERONIKA
I'm not trying to win. I just— sometimes I feel like you remember things in the way that hurts you most.

JOULE 2.0 swallows.

JOULE 2.0
I really thought—
I was so sure.

VERONIKA
I know.

A pause.

VERONIKA (cont'd)
Look. I know I haven't always been fair to you.

JOULE 2.0 nods.

VERONIKA (cont'd)
But I hope—
when you think about us—
you can leave a little room for kindness.

JOULE 2.0 laughs again. Bitter this time.

JOULE 2.0
I think that might be the problem.

VERONIKA tilts her head.

JOULE 2.0 (cont'd)
I think I've been too kind. To you.

A pause.

VERONIKA
Yeah.

She exhales.

VERONIKA (cont'd)
I think you put me on a pedestal.

That lands.

JOULE 2.0
I just— I saw you.

VERONIKA (carefully)
And I think—
sometimes—
you mistake intensity for closeness.

JOULE 2.0 stiffens.

VERONIKA (cont'd)
It's been nice, hasn't it? You having other people around. New friends.

JOULE 2.0 shakes her head immediately.

JOULE 2.0
They're not you.

A pause.

VERONIKA
You feel a lot.

Silence.

VERONIKA (cont'd)
I don't want to be the center of your life.
But I do want to be in it.

JOULE 2.0
I thought we were going to be close forever.

Her voice cracks. Just once.

VERONIKA
I know.

They stand there. The chair remains untouched.

Blackout.

SCENE FOURTEEN: THE RETURN
JOULE 2.0 stands alone.

Her coat hangs nearby.

JOULE 2.0 (in tears)
Do you know how much it hurts to just watch someone fall out of love with you?

JOULE 2.0 (cont'd)
We were so close… and now… I don't know where to put all the love I reserved for her. Things were so good… until they weren't.

JOULE 2.0
She left a letter for me, but I won't open it.
I don't know what it says, but I know what it doesn't say.
It doesn't say: I'm sorry, I'm coming home, and things will be exactly as they used to be.
It won't make me forget her.

It won’t take her out of my vacation photos.
It won’t unink the tattoo on my arm.

JOULE 2.0
She never thought about me much, and now she probably doesn’t think of me at all.

JOULE 2.0 takes a big sigh and walks over to her coat. She picks up the coat, puts it on. She attempts to recover the persona of the NARRATOR.

NARRATOR (fragile)
What’s life without a little drama? Joule will eventually understand that this was—

She stops. Swallows.

NARRATOR (cont’d)
—that this was the best thing that ever happened to her.

NARRATOR
Because heartbreak refines us. No… because freedom often disguises itself as loss. Joule’s free to reach her potential…

She falters.

NARRATOR (soft)
She’ll do things right this time.

Silence. She looks out at the audience. Not confident. Not convincing.

Blackout.

END